

Split tenselessness:

Tense, aspect, and counterfactuality in Kanien'kéha

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1 Introduction

Kanien'kéha event verbs are marked for one of three aspects.

- (1) a.
- b.
- c.

The aspects are typically treated as morphologically/syntactically/semantically as a single kind of suffix.¹

- (2) **Morphological asymmetry I: modal marking of perfective**
 - a.
 - b.
- (3) **Morphological asymmetry II: tense marking of non-perfective verbs**
 - a.
 - b.
- (4) **Morphological asymmetry III: modal marking of non-perfective**
 - a.
 - b.

My main aim today is to show that we should take the morphological asymmetry seriously. That is:

¹work arguign otherwise: baker-travis, but also lounsbury's definition of the stem includes stative/progressive

- Perfective aspect relates *events* to *possible worlds*, but not to specific times
(We need to know what set of worlds to which we are asserting the existence of an event)
- Non-perfective aspects relate the *runtime of events* to *times in the evaluation world*.
(We are talking about the)

Put another way, I argue that perfective aspect verbs in Kanien'kéha are “tenseless”, whereas non-perfective aspect verbs are “tensed”. See ? for a similar claim.

I will spell this out in a framework using a *branching time* model.

Uncited Kanien'kéha examples are from my notes working with ... *Niawen'kó:wa'*. This work builds on joint work with Katya Morgunova, Willie Myers, Arihwí:saks Colin Benedict.

2 Obligatory tense with non-perfective aspects

In this section, my aims are

- ① argue that Kanien'kéha imperfective and perfect aspect verbs have obligatory tense
- ② show that covert tenses are part of the paradigm
- ③ provide a referential/deictic analysis of tense in Kanien'kéha

2.1 Overt tense morphology

2.2 Covert tenses: temporal identity under ellipsis and cessation implicatures

2.3 Covert deictic tenses

ellipsis account

cessation account (contrast with Gatchalian 2025, who uses an existential account)

present asymmetrically entails past, so if you use past, you implicate not present.

2.4 Interim summary

3 Tenselessness with perfective aspect

Given that the lexicon of Kanien'kéha has covert tenses, we cannot infer from the morphological asymmetry in () that punctuals have no tense – they may be obligatorily covert.

3.1 Counterfactual conditionals

3.1.1 Worlds and times

Assumptions: branching times, worlds are branches along time (World-Time pairs, Schulz idea)

adapted from von Prince formalization

- (5) **Definition.** An index i is the set of propositions true at that index. (Kratzer)

(6) **Definition.** A proposition p is true at index i iff $p \in i$

(7) **Definition.** For an interval of indices $[i, i']$, p

3.2 The modalizer,

3.3 Temporal reference without tense

4 Some consequences

We arrive at a picture of Kanien'kéha along the following lines:

4.1 Two ways to identify the domain of quantifiers over indices

Domain restriction by Mod Deictic variable that is restricted by tense (Bochnak 2016)

4.2 Reference time is crucial for Kanien'kéha, not [PAST]

For most accounts, it is PAST tense that does the crucial work in deriving counterfactuality.

My account shows something more broad. I argued that Kanien'kéha perfective aspect verbs lack a distinct reference time (needed to anchor the counterfactual modal's accessibility relation at a time other than the context interval)

4.3 Temporal